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"Gimmicks are an integral part of his politics. He'll do anything for his survival and to get ahead in politics. He's trying hard to please the RSS–BJP leadership by keeping the politics of polarisation alive"

AKHIL GOGOI
Raijor Dal founder and Shivsagar MLA



MINOR WARS A 'child marriage' suspect in custody in Guwahati

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"Once he embraces an ideology or path, he goes deep into it. Whether you call it Hindutva or nationalism, he was quick to demonstrate its significance by his actions on issues such as drug trafficking and illegal encroachment"

PROF. NANI GOPAL MAHANTA
Advisor, Assam education department

vals Congress, AIUDF and BPF. "Yes, I run 50 per cent of the Congress," he told INDIA TODAY last December. Recently, former Meghalaya CM Mukul Sangma claimed that he moved from the Congress to TMC in 2021 because Sarma had been deciding Congress candidates for the elections.

THE NEW POSTER BOY

When he is not making or breaking governments, the Assam CM has been making news for reasons that often trigger sharp divides in sociopolitical discourse. Critics claim that many of his government's missions, ostensibly to initiate social reforms, such as the drive against drug abuse, cattle smuggling, illegal encroachment on public land, unauthorised madrasas and child marriages, are aimed at harassing one particular community—the immigrant Muslims of Assam. They say it's the Congress-turned-BJP leader's desperate attempts to inveigle himself with the RSS-BJP and their Hindutva agenda. "Gimmicks have always been an integral part of his politics," says Shivsagar MLA Akhil Gogoi, his rival from college days and now chief of a political party, the Raijor Dal. "He will do anything to survive and get ahead in politics. His next goal is to enter national politics, which is why he is trying hard to please the RSS-BJP leadership with this politics of polarisation."

Sarma responds to such criticism with characteristic nonchalance, even if the controversies are piling up. One such contentious issue has been the use of brute force by the police in tackling 'social evils'. Since May 10, 2021, when he took oath as CM, some 60 encounters have taken place in Assam. During this period, the Assam police's handling of crime and criminals has displayed a specific pattern—arrested accused often try to flee from custody, 'forcing' the police to open fire. Consequently, most accused either end up shot dead or, if they are lucky, in hospital with severe injuries.

Sarma is unapologetic about this crime-busting model: "Shooting should be the pattern if a criminal tries to escape police custody...there is no place for sympathy for people accused of heinous crimes such as rape, drug peddling or cow smuggling," he says. What has worked in his favour is that most of these encounters have earned him massive support in Assam. "Sarma does not fight shy of calling a spade a spade," says Ram Madhav of the RSS, who was instrumental in Sarma's move to the BJP. "He is not bothered about political correctness. That's his strength and it has captured the imagination of people across the country, not just in Assam."

This "positive reaction" has emboldened him to subtly polarise every incident to consolidate the Hindu vote bank in Assam where the rise of the Muslim population, particularly the alleged illegal immigrants from Bangladesh, has been a cause of serious anxiety among original inhabitants (between 1971-1991, the Muslim population grew by 77.4 per cent while for the Hindus, it was 41.9 per cent).

The resentment against the illegal immigrants had led to a six-year-long Assam agitation that ended in 1985 with the Union government agreeing to, among other things, update the National Register of Citizenship (NRC) to detect illegal immigrants. While the NRC was finally updated in 2019, rendering 1.9 million individuals in Assam ineligible for citizenship, no action has been taken on it yet.

Meanwhile, the BJP has successfully converted the religion-neutral conflict between indigenous communities and illegal immigrants into a Hindu-Muslim discourse. So, when on July 7, Vineet Bagaria, a 32-year-old businessman in Assam's Dibrugarh died by suicide following threats from three individuals, CM Sarma kept repeating the name of one accused—Baidulla Khan. "I'm worried. There could be many Baidullas roaming around in Dibrugarh. I don't know if we are discussing Dibrugarh or Dhubri or Jammu and Kashmir,"